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133 years on, Kasba Ganpati still leads with faith and purpose

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MIDC warns Hotel Kalasagar of punitive action over alleged unauthorised construction on storm-water drain

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Patients worried as LIC HFL removes life support of Niramaya Hospital over loan default

IT'S TIME FOR DISCHARGE!

Tribunal, HC orders on vacating mortgaged property flouted

Chinchwad health facility told to stop admitting new patients

| Vikas Shinde | feedback@punemirror.com
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The condition of Niramaya Hospital in Chinchwad can best be described as critical. LIC Housing Finance Ltd has issued directions to the health facility to vacate the premises and hand over the mortgaged property, apparently for defaulting on loan repayment.

Worse still, more than 45 patients undergoing treatment at the facility are facing uncertainty. The LIC HFL order, issued on August 29, states that the patients be shifed out and no new patients admitted to the facility.

The financial firm has made it clear that it will not be responsible for any loss of life, financial loss or legal complications arising from non-compliance with a court order.

The LIC HFL public notice states: "The Niramaya Hospital management should immediately and strictly comply with the relevant court order. Vacant and peaceful physical possession of the mortgaged property be handed over immediately."

As part of the legal process, the hospital is required to safely shift the patients currently admitted to other hospitals while following medical protocols.

In view of the present serious situation and the legal dispute, the management of the hospital has also been directed to immediately stop admitting new patients for treatment. Since the process of taking possession of the property is under way, it is feared that admitting new patients could put their health and safety at risk.

CONTINUED ON PAGE 4 »

> We have filed a fresh appeal in the Bombay High Court against the order issued by the Debt Recovery Tribunal, Pune. The judicial process is still under way. We cannot comment further on the matter.
>
> —**Dr Kisan Munde,** Director, Niramaya Hospital



Nifty closes at 24,055, Sensex slips marginally
— Benchmark domestic indices ended marginally lower on Tuesday amidst escalating geopolitical tensions in West Asia and higher crude oil prices. The NSE Nifty 50 index closed at 24,055.80, down 24.60 points or 0.10 per cent, while the BSE Sensex ended at 76,944.28, lower by 12.99 points or 0.02 per cent.

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FOR DEVOTEES' COMFORT

Central Railway announces 262 Ganpati special trains

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Central Railway has announced 262 Ganpati Special train trips for the upcoming Ganesh festival to facilitate the smooth movement of passengers travelling to their native places.

"These additional services are aimed at easing the seasonal rush and providing passengers with safe, comfortable and convenient travel options during the festival period," said the CR in a statement on Tuesday.

The special services comprise 200 Reserved Special train trips, including AC Specials and trains with a combination of AC, Sleeper and General coaches, along with 62 Unreserved Special train trips.

These services are planned from Mumbai, Pune and Nagpur to various destinations across the Konkan region of Maharashtra and Goa.

Of the 200 Reserved Special train trips, 112 are to-and-fro services to Sawantwadi Road, 64 trips are to Ratnagiri and 24 trips are to Madgaon.

The special services are scheduled to commence from September 9, and have already received an encouraging response from passengers.

As of date, a total of 1,17,682 passengers have booked their journeys on these Reserved Ganpati Special trains.

These additional services are intended to provide passengers with greater flexibility in planning their festival travel well in advance. The enhanced capacity will enable a larger number of passengers to travel to their native places and celebrate Ganpati safely and conveniently with their families, relatives, and loved ones.

Given the expected increase in passenger footfall during the Ganpati festival, CR has undertaken a series of measures across its network to ensure smooth passenger movement, better crowd management and enhanced passenger convenience.

Additional ticket counters have been arranged at various stations to facilitate faster and smoother ticketing. Holding areas have also been created at major stations to regulate passenger movement and manage crowds in an orderly manner.

To further support passengers during the festival rush, arrangements have been made for drinking water, food and toilet facilities with the assistance of various NGOs. Queue management systems will be implemented for orderly boarding on special trains, supported by the additional deployment of Railway Protection Force (RPF) personnel and ticket checking staff.

THE MEASURES

- Additional ticket counters at various stations to facilitate smooth ticketing
- Holding areas at major stations for better crowd management
- Free drinking water, food and toilet facilities for passengers with the assistance of various NGOs
- Queue management systems for orderly boarding of passengers on special trains, with deployment of additional RPF personnel and ticket checking staff
- Enhanced presence of Railway Protection Force and ticket checking staff at key locations across stations to ensure passenger safety, security and smooth movement

CR has advised passengers to reach the station at least 30 minutes before the scheduled departure of their trains.

CR goes the extra mile...

Staff help NRI passenger deboard train in Karjat, return to Pune

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The passenger, Manijes Pavri, with the railway staff at Karjat junction

Demonstrating its commitment to passenger safety and care, Central Railway staff extended timely assistance to an NRI passenger who was unable to alight from Train No. 22226 Vande Bharat Express at Pune.

Manijes Pavri, an NRI passenger from Canada, was unable to deboard the train in Pune. Upon receiving information, the CR personnel promptly made arrangements to ensure the passenger could alight safely at the next suitable station.

"Accordingly, the train was facilitated to halt at Karjat station at 10:20 a.m. and departed at 10:23 a.m., after railway staff assisted Pavri in safely deboarding it.

The railway staff further extended assistance by facilitating her onward journey back to Pune in another train," Pravin Patil, Senior PRO, Central Railway, told Pune Times Mirror.

The incident highlights the readiness of railway personnel to go beyond routine duties and provide timely support to passengers, particularly in situations requiring immediate attention and care.

"Central Railway continues to place the safety, convenience and well-being of its passengers at the forefront of its operations, reinforcing the ethos of 'Passenger First' through prompt action and compassionate service," a CR official stated.

EDITORIAL

MIRROR REFLECTS

Write to him at amlan.hazarika@punemirror.com

Rooftops of the world getting more volatile

Nepal tragedy warns us of things to come

The recent flash floods in Nepal, triggered by a catastrophic glacier collapse, serve as a stark manifestation of a natural world responding to environmental destabilisation.

This disaster, which unleashed a torrent of ice, rock, and mud across the Bhote Koshi and Trishuli river valleys, is a haunting reminder that the environment is becoming increasingly unforgiving in the face of human-driven climate change.

When the bedrock and ice of the Lirung massif detached, it resulted in a magnitude 5.2 seismic event, demonstrating that human-caused environmental degradation is not just a distant, abstract threat but a present, violent reality for mountain populations.

Why are Himalayan glaciers melting faster?

Himalayan glaciers are melting at an accelerating rate because the region is warming nearly twice as fast as the global average, a phenomenon known as elevation-dependent warming.

While global carbon dioxide emissions are the primary driver, local factors significantly exacerbate the melt. Black carbon deposits — soot from brick kilns, diesel exhaust, and biomass burning — settle on the ice, darkening its surface. This reduces the ice's albedo (reflectivity), causing it to absorb more solar energy and melt at an unprecedented pace.

Primary reasons researchers point to:

The destabilisation of the Himalayas is multifaceted. Researchers emphasise the degradation of mountain permafrost — the "cryospheric glue" that has held rock and ice together for millennia. As temperatures rise, this natural cement thaws, weakening steep rock slopes and leading to catastrophic structural failures.

Furthermore, the rapid retreat of glaciers has left behind unstable landscapes, where new glacial lakes form behind natural, fragile dams of loose debris. These lakes are prone to "glacial lake outburst floods" (GLOFs), which, when triggered by an avalanche or heavy rain, release vast volumes of water with destructive force.

Increased human activity, including infrastructure development, tourism, and hydropower projects, has further placed more people and assets in the path of these inevitable hazards.

Precautionary ways to slow the melt

Reducing the scale of such disasters requires a dual approach of mitigation and adaptation.

Decarbonization and emission cuts: The ultimate solution is limiting global temperature rise. This necessitates drastic reductions in CO2 and black carbon emissions to slow the rate of glacier retreat.

Transboundary Cooperation: Because Himalayan river systems cross political borders, countries must establish institutionalised mechanisms — such as dedicated hotlines — for real-time data sharing regarding glacier movement, lake levels, and river flow.

Advanced monitoring: Utilising high-resolution satellite imagery (InSAR) and ground-level sensors can provide critical warning times, allowing downstream populations to evacuate before a hazard evolves into a disaster.

Resilient infrastructure: Construction in fragile mountain zones must be strictly regulated. Infrastructure should be designed or relocated to withstand the idiosyncrasies of mountain ecology, rather than imposing artificial designs on unstable terrain.

The end line

The Nepal tragedy is not a freak accident, but a preview of a future where mountains — once considered immutable "rooftops of the world" — are becoming increasingly volatile. The path forward demands that we move beyond ad-hoc responses; we must honour the limits of the mountain ecosystem by prioritising science-led adaptation, cutting emissions at the source, and ensuring that our development footprint does not turn nature's inevitable hazards into preventable human catastrophes.

— AMLAN HAZARIKA

CHEATING VIA SPY CAM SPECS

3 candidates appearing for PMC Junior Engineer Exam allegedly photographed question paper, leaked it via mobile phone; six booked



AI GENERATED IMAGE

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With advances in technology and the emergence of new gadgets, miscreants are devising sophisticated methods to cheat in crucial recruitment and other competitive examinations. In one such startling case of exam malpractice, three candidates appearing for the Pune Municipal Corporation's (PMC) Junior Engineer recruitment examination allegedly used cameras concealed inside their spectacles to photograph the question paper and leak it using a mobile phone they sneaked into the examination hall.

The Shivajinagar police registered a case against six persons, including the three candidates, two employees of Tata Consultancy Services (TCS), and one unidentified person, in connection with the alleged malpractice at the Chikalthana examination centre in Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar.

Paper leak triggers probe

The matter came to light after the question paper was allegedly circulated on social media. Following this, the PMC asked TCS and the Institute of Banking Personnel Selection (IBPS), the agencies responsible for conducting the exam, to investigate.

The PMC had advertised 169 Junior Engineer posts in 2024. The examination, postponed several times, was finally held in April 2026 across centres in Pune, Mumbai, Nagpur, Amravati, Kolhapur, Nanded and Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar, with more than 22,000 candidates appearing over three days — April 22, 23 and 29.

CCTV footage exposes scam

During its investigation, IBPS scanned CCTV footage from the examination centres and flagged the movements of three candidates at the Chikalthana centre as suspicious. The candidates allegedly had miniature cameras hidden in their spectacles.

Investigators found that the three candidates spent nearly 30 minutes without attempting the paper after the exam began, during which they allegedly used the concealed cameras to photograph it. They then reportedly left the hall on the pretext of visiting the washroom.

Police suspect a mobile phone was made available to them there, through which the photographs were allegedly sent outside. The candidates reportedly spent considerable time in the washroom before returning to complete the paper.

The candidates have been identified as Gajanan Pache, Shivshankar Shelgave and Vishnu Kant Waghmare. All three reportedly scored more than 90 marks and were subsequently selected for the Junior Engineer posts.

Alleged involvement of TCS staff

The probe also flagged the alleged involvement of two TCS employees, Yogesh Rathod, an electrician, and Vikas Gaikwad, who was responsible for providing infrastructure at the centre. Police suspect the two allegedly helped the candidates carry out the malpractice.

A case has been registered at Shivajinagar police station, and four police teams have been dispatched to Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar, Latur, Hingoli and Jalna to trace and apprehend the accused.

Wider racket suspected

The controversy has since widened,

> "Three candidates were found to have gone to the washroom and later returned. A mobile phone was found in the washroom. We suspect the candidates may have used cameras concealed in their spectacles.
>
> — **Prajit Nair,** Additional Commissioner, PMC

with several candidates who appeared for the examination alleging that the malpractice may not be limited to the three identified so far. More than 100 engineers have reportedly raised concerns over a possible larger racket and demanded a detailed probe into the examination process.

The PMC, however, has maintained that its investigation has so far established the involvement of only three candidates, and has declined to cancel the entire examination.

PMC Additional Commissioner Prajit Nair confirmed that a case had been registered at Shivajinagar police station following the alleged cheating in the civil engineering examination.

"Five persons have been booked in the case, including three examination candidates and two permanent TCS employees. The incident took place at the Chikalthana examination centre in Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar," Nair said.

He added that the PMC had sought an investigation after a video and exam-related material allegedly surfaced on Telegram, following which IBPS examined the footage and other material.

"IBPS analysed the movements of 545 candidates. Three candidates were found to have gone to the washroom and later returned. A mobile phone was found in the washroom. We suspect the candidates may have used cameras concealed in their spectacles. They reportedly solved the paper during the last half-hour of the examination," Nair said.

Police probe ongoing

Senior Police Inspector Girish Dighavkar of Shivajinagar police station told Pune Times Mirror that the investigation was still underway. "We are still investigating the case. Further details will emerge as the investigation progresses," Dighavkar said.

Minor 'used' in ganja trade

61-year-old held with 21 kg marijuana; juvenile detained

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The Crime Branch's Unit 6 busted a ganja trafficking racket in Suraksha Nagar, Hadapsar, arresting a 61-year-old man after uncovering that a 17-year-old boy was allegedly used to facilitate the drug's sale. The crackdown led to the seizure of 21.18 kg of ganja and other material worth Rs 11.44 lakh.

The arrested accused was identified as Popat Maruti Padule, 61, a resident of Naveen MHADA Colony, Suraksha Nagar. The minor (17), a boy in conflict with the law, was also detained during the operation. A case has been registered at Wanawadi police station under Sections 8(c), 20(b)(ii)(C) and 29 of the NDPS Act.

Tip-off leads to crackdown

According to the Crime Branch, the action followed intelligence received by the Unit 6 team about narcotics movement in the area. Acting on the information, officers intensified patrolling in Suraksha Nagar and began monitoring suspicious activity.



Crime Branch team with the arrested accused and seized contraband

Police Inspector Santosh Shethe of Unit 6 said the team spotted the suspects travelling on a motorcycle during patrolling. Their behaviour raised suspicion, leading officers to intercept them and conduct a search.

"The team was conducting patrolling in the area when we noticed the accused on a motorcycle. We became suspicious of their movements and stopped them. The subsequent search led to the recovery of the contraband," Shethe said.

Investigators suspect the juvenile was used as part of the distribution mechanism, allegedly making it easier for the network to operate without attracting immediate attention. Police are now examining how long the minor had been involved and whether other youngsters were also drawn into the drug trade.

Main supplier still at large

The probe has also widened to identify the source of the narcotics. Shethe said the person believed to be the main supplier has not yet been traced.

"The main person involved in the supply chain is still at large. We are working to identify and trace him. He appears to have a background in similar NDPS-related activities, and we are checking his previous involvement as part of the investigation," Shethe said.

Police are also examining the communication records and movements of the arrested accused to determine where the ganja was sourced from and where it was intended to be distributed. Investigators are likely to question him about his contacts and the possible involvement of others in the network.

The recovered ganja has been seized as part of the investigation.

Padule was produced before the court, which remanded him to three days of police custody. Wanawadi police are conducting further investigation into the case. The juvenile has been placed under the appropriate protocols for minors in conflict with the law.

DJs WILL BE ALLOWED OR NOT?

Oppn leaders urge CM to make stand clear

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The controversy over the use of DJs and loud sound systems during the upcoming Ganeshotsav has now spilt into the political arena.

Supriya Sule, the NCP (SP) MP on Tuesday demanded that Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis clearly state whether DJs will be permitted and issue appropriate directions.

Aam Aadmi Party leader Mukund Kirdat too accused the CM of ignoring the physical and mental distress caused to Pune residents by excessive noise.

Speaking at the BJP's Maharashtra state executive meeting in Pune on Monday, Fadnavis appealed to Puneites to avoid getting drawn into the DJ controversy and set an example for the state by celebrating Ganeshotsav in a traditional way. However, he did not announce any clear administrative decision on whether DJs would be banned or permitted.



Sule said, "Everyone must follow the Supreme Court's judgment and the rules under the law regarding DJs and Dolby sound. The chief minister should clearly say whether DJs are permitted or not."

She suggested that the administration should convene a joint meeting with Ganesh mandals and arrive at a solution acceptable to all sides.

"Ganeshotsav should not be viewed through a political lens," she said, recalling that Lokmanya Tilak had started the public celebration of Ganeshotsav with the objective of promoting social unity.



Supriya Sule

AAP leader Kirdat said the citizens of Pune have already made their opposition to deafening DJs clear through an online petition, an email campaign, street marches and protests. Despite this, he alleged, the CM was adopting a 'let both sides have their way' approach.

Kirdat claimed that a survey conducted by engineering students last year had recorded noise levels of nearly 110 decibels during processions. "With the daytime permissible limit in residential areas being 55 decibels, such excessive noise could cause permanent hearing damage."

The AAP leader added that patients with heart ailments, senior citizens, young children, pedestrians and pets were also affected by high-volume sound. Kirdat demanded that prescribed noise limits be strictly enforced not only during Ganeshotsav but also during processions held for all religious, political and social events.

"Pune has the capacity to celebrate Ganeshotsav traditionally and culturally, and should set an example for the entire Maharashtra," he said.

The CM's remarks assume significance as the BJP's local leaders and office-bearers in Pune appear divided over whether DJs and laser lights should be permitted during the festival.

While one section has supported allowing DJs in response to demands from party workers and Ganesh mandals, another has backed traditional instruments such as dhol-tasha, and strict adherence to noise pollution regulations.

Kondhwa cops bust drug ring

Seize contraband worth ₹8 lakh in 48 hours in two separate operations; suspect Mumbai link in MD case

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Kondhwa police registered two cases under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act within 48 hours, arresting two people and seizing hydroponic ganja and mephedrone (MD) worth nearly Rs 8 lakh, officials said on Tuesday.

The operations, carried out on August 28 and August 31, also led to the recovery of cash, mobile phones, a vehicle, weighing machines and other material allegedly linked to the drug trade.

MD seizure at a lodge

In the first raid on August 28, police acted on a tip-off that a man was consuming mephedrone in Room No. 405 of Paradise Inn Lodge. A team led by police constable Keshav Hirve apprehended Azim Salim Sheikh, 37, a resident of Bhavani Peth, at the spot.

A search of the room yielded 12.10 grams of mephedrone powder valued at Rs 2.42 lakh, along with Rs 5,500 in cash, two mobile phones worth Rs 16,000 and 15 syringes. The total value of the seizure was pegged at around Rs 2.64 lakh.

According to Senior Police Inspector Santosh Khetmalas of Kondhwa police station, the action was based on confidential information and the investigation has now been expanded to trace the supply chain.

"We have now begun investigating the further supply chain to identify from where the MD was procured and who else is involved," he said, adding that preliminary leads pointed to an absconding supplier based in Mumbai, who police are working to trace.

Sheikh was produced before a court on September 1, with police seeking his further custody to probe the network.

Hydroponic ganja recovered during patrol

In the second operation on August 31, a Kondhwa police team on anti-narcotics patrol spotted a man behaving suspiciously near a moped in the Haddi area, close to L.K. Apartment on Sarvajanik Road in Ajmera Park, Kondhwa Khurd.

The man, identified as Amir Akbar Sheikh, 36, of Ajmera Park, was found in possession of 149 grams of greenish hydroponic ganja valued at Rs 5.21 lakh. Police also seized Rs 3,300 in cash, a white Vego vehicle (registration MH 12 HH 8453), two electronic weighing scales and several empty packing bags of assorted sizes. The total value of items seized in this case was put at Rs 5.49 lakh.

Khetmalas noted that hydroponic ganja is a higher-value variety than conventional cannabis. "The accused has told us during the preliminary inquiry that he had been involved in this activity for around four months and was doing it to meet his personal expenses. We are verifying his statement and investigating whether he was supplying the drug to others," he said.

Police said the two cases are being probed separately, with efforts underway to trace the larger network behind the procurement and distribution of the narcotics.





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IT'S TIME FOR DISCHARGE!

CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1

On July 22, officials of LIC HFL reached Niramaya Hospital after making all the necessary arrangements to take physical possession of the property. However, the hospital was fully operational at the time. A large number of patients were found to be undergoing treatment. As a result, the possession process was kept in abeyance.

The notice states: "The responsibility for treating patients currently admitted to the hospital, discharging them or shifting them to other healthcare centres will rest entirely with Niramaya Hospital. LIC Housing Finance will not be responsible for any difficulty, inconvenience, accident, loss of life or financial loss arising from violation of the court order or during the possession process. The entire and final responsibility for all such possible consequences will rest with the Niramaya Hospital management."

The notice has caused considerable concern in the Chinchwad area. Relatives of patients undergoing treatment for serious illnesses at the hospital are worried. Speaking to Pune Times Mirror, a patient's family member said, "If serious patients have to be shifted suddenly, where are we supposed to take them? Who will be responsible if their lives are put at risk?"

All eyes are now on the steps Niramaya Hospital management takes to ensure the safety of patients, and whether the local administration or health department will intervene.

HC GAVE 2-WEEK EXTENSION IN JULY

The Debt Recovery Tribunal, Pune, in an order issued on June 26, 2026, directed the Niramaya Hospital management and the borrowers to submit an undertaking regarding shifting the patients to other hospitals. Subsequently, an order issued by the Bombay High Court on July 7, 2026, granted a two-week extension for shifting the patients. The LIC Housing Finance Ltd said the hospital management failed to act despite the court granting repeated opportunities.

CM fires back at CJP, RaGa

Fadnavis sounds poll battle cry: 10 lakh workers will reach out to two crore young voters

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While the Bharatiya Janata Party's central leadership has appeared somewhat defensive against the growing aggression of the 'Cockroach Janata Party' (CJP), which has dominated national headlines following its protest at Delhi's Jantar Mantar, and Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis chose a starkly different approach in Maharashtra, going on the offensive.

At the BJP's Maharashtra state executive meeting held in Pune on Monday, Fadnavis launched a sharp attack on both the CJP and Rahul Gandhi. Addressing around 4,000 party representatives, he did not merely target the Opposition, he also laid out, in detail, the welfare schemes, employment generation and economic progress achieved by the Mahayuti and BJP government in the state over the past few years, in what appeared to be an attempt to instil fresh confidence among party workers.



Supreme Court setback, unease in Delhi

These political developments unfolded against the backdrop of an important courtroom development in Delhi. A petition seeking a ban on the CJP's protest, set to resume in Delhi on September 5, came up for hearing before the Supreme Court on Monday. The Solicitor General of India had raised concerns over law and order and sought the court's intervention. However, a bench led by Chief Justice of India, Justice Surya Kant, clearly declined to impose any ban or stay on the protest. Notably, it was an earlier remark by Justice Surya Kant himself, made in the context of unemployed youth, that gave rise to the term 'cockroach' — a remark that eventually led to the formation of the Cockroach Janata Party and the large protest at Jantar Mantar on July 20.

Against this backdrop, the Supreme Court's decision not to restrain the proposed agitation, and Fadnavis' aggressive political response in Maharashtra have added a new dimension to the issue.

Following the Jantar Mantar protest, BJP's central leadership appeared somewhat guarded in Parliament and in Delhi's political circles, with senior party leaders seen avoiding an aggressive stance on the issue even in the Lok Sabha. Against this difficult political backdrop, Fadnavis chose to take the fight directly to the Opposition from Pune, rather than adopt a defensive posture.

Ideology versus issue-based politics

Meanwhile, Rahul Gandhi's interactive programme for female students in Pune, 'Chhatron Ki Goonj', had drawn a strong response. Referring to this, Fadnavis levelled sharp criticism at the Congress leader, remarking that the programme was not "Chhatron Ki Goonj" but "Jhooth Ki Goonj" (an echo of lies). Fadnavis said Rahul Gandhi and the Opposition were unable to mount a direct ideological challenge to the BJP's core philosophy of nationalism and Hindutva, and were therefore raising emotionally charged issues such as patriarchy and social inequality to mislead the younger generation, particularly young women. He cautioned party workers to remain intellectually and politically prepared to counter what he called the Opposition's false narrative.

Gen Z and women voters emerge as key focus

Political analysts believe that Gen Z are increasingly drawn to the CJP's protests. At the same time, there is growing concern within BJP circles that this Opposition strategy could alienate the youth and women voters who formed the core of the party's support base in its 2014 and 2019 General Election victories.

With this concern in mind, the Pune executive meeting deliberately passed only two main resolutions — one focused on youth, the other on women, as Fadnavis sought to re-anchor both constituencies to the party by presenting a detailed account of the government's performance.

A performance ledger: jobs, startups and FDI

In his address, Fadnavis countered Opposition allegations with figures, claiming the state had provided government jobs to 1.2 lakh youth in recent years, that Maharashtra leads the country in the number of startups, and that the state consistently ranks first in attracting foreign direct investment (FDI) due to industry-friendly policies. He also pointed to women-centric initiatives, including the Ladki Bahin scheme, financial support to self-help groups, free higher education, and a 50 percent concession on state transport travel as having brought about significant change in women's lives.

CJP means 'Congress Jitao Party'

Fadnavis also attacked the CJP while referring to Rahul Gandhi's 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' initiative. He said the small CJP party currently in existence was actually a "Congress Jitao Party".

He alleged that four or five youngsters were merely being projected and claimed that the organisation had been created to help bring the Congress back to power. Calling Rahul Gandhi's red copy of the Constitution mere political theatre, he asserted that only the BJP could truly safeguard Dr B.R. Ambedkar's Constitution.

BJP workers told to counter the narrative

On outreach, Fadnavis noted that over 40 percent of digital traffic now flows through Instagram alone, urging workers to move beyond WhatsApp and Facebook. With roughly 2 crore voters aged 18 to 26 in the state, the BJP has set a target of mobilising 10 lakh dedicated workers statewide to reach them directly — a strategy party leaders hope will define its campaign ahead of the coming Assembly elections.

Fadnavis called upon BJP workers to counter what he described as the Congress' fake narrative with facts. He said workers had the responsibility of effectively communicating the development work undertaken by the Centre and the state, welfare schemes and the BJP's ideological position to the people.

Shooting brings highway traffic to a grinding halt

Videography of new SUV leads to huge jam; four booked

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What was meant to be a celebration of a newly purchased SUV turned into a traffic hazard after a group allegedly stopped and slowed vehicles on the busy Pune-Bengaluru highway to shoot a reel.

Bavdhan police have registered a case against four people, including the SUV owner and a photographer.

The incident took place around 4.15 pm on August 27 on the stretch between the Sahyadri Mahindra showroom and Bhujbal Chowk in Wakad. The road is among the busiest stretches of the Pune-Bengaluru highway and witnesses heavy vehicular movement throughout the day.

According to the police, the accused allegedly brought their vehicles to a halt on the highway while using a drone for making a video to celebrate the purchase of the SUV.

The vehicles reportedly slowed down and stopped in the middle of the road, causing traffic behind them to halt over a considerable distance.

The incident allegedly involved two Fortuner SUVs that were being used to escort the newly purchased vehicle. Police said the vehicles were positioned around and behind the SUV, allegedly obstructing the movement of other vehicles.

A video of the incident has since surfaced on social media and gone viral. The footage reportedly shows a black SUV decorated with a floral garland stopping in the middle of the busy road while the group records the vehicle. The video has drawn criticism from social media users, with many questioning the decision to block a major highway merely for a celebratory reel.

The FIR names 32-year-old Somnath Ashok Kedari, a resident of Kusgaon in Maval taluka, as the owner of the newly purchased SUV. The drivers of the two Fortuner SUVs have also been named in the case for allegedly helping block or restrict traffic around the vehicle.

Police action

The fourth accused is Soham Chavan, owner of SC Photography, who was allegedly hired to shoot the video. Police have included the photographer in the case on allegations that he participated in the activity that resulted in the obstruction of traffic.

The police have booked the accused under Sections 285, 281 and 223 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). Section 285 relates to danger or obstruction in a public way, while Section 281 deals with rash driving on a public way. Section 223 pertains to disobedience of an order lawfully promulgated by a public servant.

The accused have also been booked under Sections 184 and 122 of the Motor Vehicles Act. Section 184 deals with dangerous driving, while Section 122 concerns leaving a vehicle in a position that causes or is likely to cause danger, obstruction or undue inconvenience to other road users.

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Dates for application:
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Bamboo artisans battle rising costs

Ganeshotsav sales fall 50 pc as thermocol takes over



PHOTOS: AJAY GANGURDE



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Thirteen days before Ganeshotsav, the narrow lanes of Burud Gully near Pune's Mandai should be humming with activity—bamboo strips stacked in bundles, hammers tapping away, customers haggling over the season's best decoration. Instead, the artisans here are counting losses and wondering how much longer the craft can hold on.

Sales of traditional bamboo decorations made by Burud traders in the main Mandai area have fallen by as much as 50 percent this year. Soaring raw material prices, rising labour costs and the growing preference among customers for ready-made plastic and thermocol products have created a double blow for traders in Burud Galli.

A five-generation trade running into losses

For five generations, the More family has worked this trade, shaping raw bamboo into lotus-shaped seats, tiny ornamental boats, traditional hut-style mantaps, and cradles and swings for Bappa's idol—the kind of handcrafted decorations that once defined a Pune Ganeshotsav. However, this year the business is down by nearly half.

Raw bamboo that cost Rs 5 a foot last year now costs Rs 8, a jump that has rippled straight through to the finished product. Combined with rising labour costs for skilled artisans, prices of finished decorative pieces have climbed 25 to 30 per cent compared to last year. Pieces that once moved quickly are now sitting in the market priced between Rs 500 and Rs 1,500. Artisans say buyers simply walk away if they push the price any higher. The market is too slow to absorb it.

The thermocol shift

But it is not only about rising costs. A quieter, more permanent shift is under way: thermocol has steadily taken over as the decoration of choice for many households. It's cheaper, lighter to work with, easier to shape into elaborate designs, and doesn't demand the years of skill that bamboo work does.

And bamboo work does demand skill that doesn't show up on a price tag. Each decorative piece takes an artisan roughly 20 to 25 minutes to make, cutting bamboo strips to exact measurements and nailing them into place to build a structure sturdy enough to hold up through the festival. Get the cut wrong, and the whole design falls apart.

A flicker of hope

Even so, all is not lost. Some customers still seek out the More family and others in Burud Galli specifically for custom orders, designs built to their own imagination, not off a shelf. There's steady, if modest, interest this year in palanquin and hut-style decorations. And traders remain cautiously hopeful that footfall will pick up in the two weeks still left before the festival, as it usually does closer to the date.

'There is still so much joy'

What keeps artisans like More going, despite thinning margins and dwindling demand, seems to be something less easily measured than profit.

"We've had to raise prices because raw material costs have gone up, but the market won't let us raise them further than this," said local trader More. "The growing use of thermocol has cut into our traditional work, and our business is down 50 percent this year. But no matter how many challenges we face, no matter how much our profits shrink, there is still so much joy in making these pieces with our own hands to welcome Bappa."

For now, that joy is what's keeping Burud Gully's oldest craft alive—one bamboo strip, one nail, one careful cut at a time.

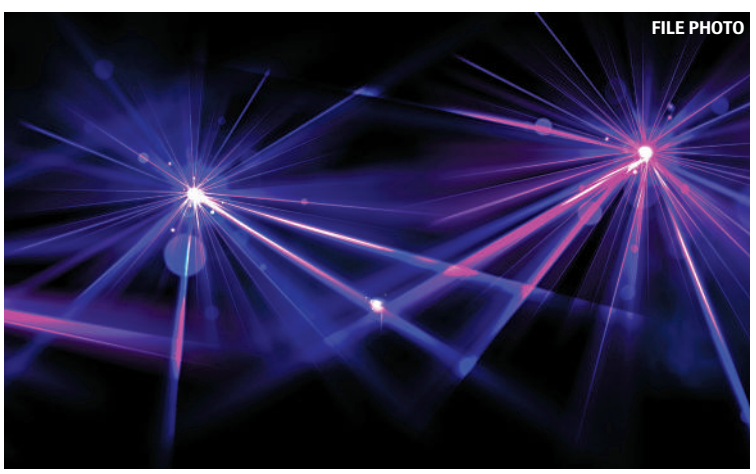
No laser lights during Ganeshotsav

District collector issues restriction; violators face action; doctors warn of risk of permanent vision loss

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Considering the potential impact of continuous exposure to laser light on eyesight, District Collector **Jitendra Dudi (in pic)** has imposed restrictions on the use of laser lights between September 14 and 25, including during Ganesh immersion processions. The order states that any individual, organisation, or Ganesh mandal found using laser lights during an immersion procession in violation of the directive will be liable for punishment and legal action under Section 223 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, along with other applicable laws.





FILE PHOTO

Under the order, individuals, organisations and Ganesh mandals participating in immersion processions have been directed not to use laser lights in violation of the restrictions. The administration has warned that strict legal action will be taken against those who fail to comply

Crowd safety cited as key concern

Ganesh festival processions traditionally draw large numbers of devotees and members of the public. With crowds expected to gather along procession routes, the district administration emphasised the need to maintain law and order and ensure the safety and well-being of citizens.

Under the order, individuals, organisations and Ganesh mandals participating in immersion processions have been directed not to use laser lights in violation of the restrictions. The administration has warned that strict legal action will be taken against those who fail to comply.

Doctors warn of retinal damage

Dr Suchita Kulkarni, Retina Specialist at the Department of Ophthalmology, Bharati Hospital and Research Centre, explained the medical risks posed by laser exposure.

"If laser beams enter the eye and strike the retina, they can cause retinal bleeding or swelling, which may result in vision loss. The loss of vision may be temporary, but if the retinal cells are damaged, it can become permanent," Dr Kulkarni said.

She added that the hospital had treated a significant number of such cases during last year's festive season. "We treated around 10 to 12 such cases during last year's festive season. Even a second of direct laser exposure can damage the eye, particularly if the beam focuses on the central part of the retina. Since it is impossible to predict when this may occur, people should avoid looking directly at laser lights," she said.

"In my opinion, the restrictions on the use of laser lights during Ganesh immersion processions are appropriate," Dr Kulkarni concluded.

Move's part of wider festival preparedness

The district administration's move comes as part of preparations to manage the festival period and ensure that public celebrations take place in an orderly manner wihtout any negative impact on people's health.

Officials said the restrictions are intended to support the smooth management of processions and help authorities maintain public order during a period when large public gatherings are expected.

A DEVOTION CENTURY OLD

Pune's first Ganpati, a timeless legacy: 133 years on, Kasba Ganpati still leads with faith and purpose



A TRADITION THAT ENDURES

The Shri Kasba Ganpati Mandal began celebrating the Sarvajanik Ganpati festival in 1893 and has since become an integral part of Pune's—and Maharashtra's—Ganeshotsav tradition.

Today, the trustees, members, volunteers and devotees of Shri Kasba Ganpati continue to observe the ten-day festival with devotion, even as they carry forward initiatives aimed at raising social awareness and educating the community on contemporary issues. In doing so, the mandal continues to offer a distinctive platform for social, environmental and economic development.

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For generations, Pune's revered first 'Manacha Ganpati' has woven together devotion, education, social welfare, culture and community service, placing tradition firmly at the heart of its celebrations.

The Shri Kasba Ganpati Sarvajanik Ganeshotsav Mandal, together with the Shri Kasba Ganpati Social Organisation, has for years run a range of social, educational and cultural initiatives alongside its religious activities. Under its student adoption scheme, 159 needy students have received educational assistance this year, with the initiative covering their school fees as well as essential study material.

According to Shrikant Shete, president of the Shri Kasba Ganpati Mandal, the mandal has also encouraged devotees to immerse Ganesh idols in water tanks rather than rivers. It has appealed to citizens to donate foodgrains to needy villagers, matching the quantity collected with a donation of its own. The mandal has further extended assistance towards restoring the library and book collection at the Bhandarkar Institute — one among several initiatives through which it continues to give back to the community.

A city's presiding deity

"Kasba Ganpati is revered as the gramadevata, or presiding deity, of Pune, and is regarded as the city's first and most honoured Manacha Ganpati. The idol was established in 1893 in Kasba Peth, one of the oldest parts of the city, and is believed to be swayambhu, or self-manifested. This year, the idol has been restored to its original form," said Shete.

The Shri Kasba Ganpati Sarvajanik Ganeshotsav Mandal is among Pune"s most prominent public Ganeshotsav organisations. Along with four other mandals, it holds a place of honour in the city's Ganesh immersion procession, with Kasba Ganpati leading the way.

Despite its stature, the mandal remains known for celebrating the festival in a traditional and simple manner, steering clear of unnecessary pomp or extravagance, even as its work extends well beyond the purely religious.

Women at the forefront

The participation of women across the mandal's activities is a distinctive feature of its work. Women take complete charge of one full day of the festival and, in a further step towards giving them a more prominent role, the mandal has appointed two women as trustees.

Education as legacy

The student adoption scheme has, over the years, benefited needy and meritorious students from several reputed schools in Pune, including Ramanbaug, Huzurpaga, Ahilyadevi, Nandadeep, Karve Sanstha and Vimalabai Garware, among others.

Shrikant Shete said the contributions of philanthropic individuals, organisations and supporters had, over the past 23 years, given hundreds of students a strong foundation to complete their education.



Khandobawadi, a settlement of around 1,000 people in Pathardi taluka, has been adopted by the Kasba Ganpati Mandal

Reaching beyond the city

In 2017, the mandal adopted Khandobawadi village in Ahmednagar district (now Ahilyanagar), where it has constructed a water tank and built the infrastructure needed to ensure water reaches villagers' homes.

Over the years, several prominent personalities, including former President Shankar Dayal Sharma and noted industrialist Shantanurao Kirloskar, have visited Kasba Ganpati to seek the blessings of Lord Ganesha.

Major social and educational initiatives

- Student adoption scheme: For more than 23 years, economically weaker students from Marathi-medium schools, Classes 5 to 10, have been adopted under the scheme, which covers school fees, stationery and books. In 2026, 159 students received assistance.
- Blood donation camps: Organised every year during Ganeshotsav.
- Library for children: A dedicated children's library has been operating in the area since 2012, with its collection and readership steadily growing.
- Community assistance: The mandal also donates computers and gym equipment for young people.
- Women's participation: Women volunteers take charge of an entire day of the festival and hold an honoured place on the mandal's board of trustees.
- Kasba Kala Karandak and cultural programmes: Various competitions are held to encourage artistic talent among children and young people.

Animal cremations spike sharply

Count doubles in July, 283 carcasses cremated last month against 141 in June; officials yet to explain surge

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Civic data on the cremation of large dead animals has thrown up a sharp and unexplained spike for the month of July, with figures nearly doubling compared to the previous month. According to Pimpri-Chinchwad Municipal Corporation (PCMC) records, a total of 1,151 large dead animals were cremated in the city over the seven-month period between January and July. Of these, as many as 283 were cremated in July alone, a sudden jump that has caught the attention of civic officials.



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Month	Cremations
January	132
February	142
March	169
April	151
May	133
June	141
July	283
Total	1,151

The sudden spike in cremations has consequently raised questions about the civic machinery in place for the transport, cremation and disposal of dead animals

A steady trend, until July

Through the earlier part of the year, the numbers had remained relatively stable. In January, 132 large dead animals were cremated, a figure that rose marginally to 142 in February. March saw a further increase to 169 cremations, before the number dipped slightly to 151 in April. May recorded 133 cremations, followed by 141 in June.

Then came July, when the figure suddenly surged to 283, an increase of 142 over June's count. In effect, the number of cremations nearly doubled within a single month.

Between January and June, a combined total of 868 large dead animals were cremated across the city. In July alone, that figure was 283, nearly a quarter of the entire seven-month total concentrated in just one month.

March had previously recorded the highest monthly figure at 169. July's count exceeded even that by 114 cremations, making the spike all the more striking, and prompting officials to take note.

Over 100% rise compared to June

June recorded 141 cremations of large dead animals, a figure that climbed to 283 in July, marking an increase of roughly 101 percent month-on-month. This makes July's tally the highest not just within the seven-month period under review, but across the entire available dataset.

Why proper disposal matters

Timely and proper disposal of large dead animals in the city is considered essential from a public health and sanitation standpoint. Delays in disposal can lead to foul odour, unhygienic conditions, and potential health risks for residents. The sudden spike in cremations has consequently raised questions about the civic machinery in place for the transport, cremation and disposal of dead animals.

Officials say the exact reason behind July's sudden rise needs to be clarified by the administration. Whether the spike is linked to monsoon-related conditions, disease outbreaks among animals, changes in livestock population, or other factors remains unclear. A clearer explanation from civic authorities, officials say, would help present a fuller picture of the situation.

PCMC has not yet issued an official statement detailing the cause of the surge, and the matter is likely to draw further scrutiny as the civic body reviews its animal disposal mechanisms in the coming weeks.

Hotel faces demolition notice

MIDC warns Hotel Kalasagar of punitive action over alleged unauthorised construction on storm-water drain; complaint filed with civic body

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Thousands of square feet of unauthorised construction is allegedly being carried out in the premises of Hotel Kalasagar in Kasarwadi. Taking serious note of the matter, the Maharashtra Industrial Development Corporation (MIDC) has issued a notice to the hotel owners. MIDC has warned that the unauthorised construction must be removed immediately on the owners' own initiative, failing which penal action and demolition proceedings will be initiated.

Meanwhile, the Sanay Chhatrapati Shasan party has filed a written complaint with Pimpri-Chinchwad Mayor Ravi Landge and Municipal Coommissioner Vijay Suryavanshi, demanding that the illegal construction be demolished without delay.

When contacted, Santosh Patil, Deputy Engineer, MIDC, Chinchwad, told Pune Times Mirror that as per MIDC rules, construction cannot be carried out on a plot without permission. "However, unauthorised construction has been observed on the Hotel Kalasagar plot. We have directed them to remove the unauthorised construction. If the encroachment on the plot is not removed, MIDC will initiate penal action," the official said.



Construction on natural drain?

According to the complaint, the Hotel Kalasagar management has undertaken extensive construction on its premises by allegedly encroaching on a natural drain passing alongside the hotel. The complaint alleges that the natural flow of the drain has been obstructed and that a three- to four-storey structure covering thousands of square feet has been constructed over it.

The construction over the drain has raised concerns that the natural flow of rainwater could be obstructed during the monsoon, potentially resulting in flooding in Kasarwadi and surrounding areas and posing a threat to the safety of residents.

In a representation submitted to the PCMC Mayor and Commissioner, the Sanay Chhatrapati Shasan party has alleged that the Hotel Kalasagar management carried out the construction without complying with government regulations and by disregarding natural drainage systems for its own financial benefit. At a time when preservation of natural drains is essential, allowing a multi-storey structure to come up over a drain amounts to an attempt to circumvent the administrative system, the representation stated.

The complainants have also cited various provisions of the Maharashtra Regional and Town Planning Act, 1966 (MRTP Act), and sought stringent legal action against the hotel. They have claimed that construction undertaken without the necessary permission or in a manner that damages natural resources can attract criminal action. The party has therefore demanded that the PCMC and MIDC conduct a joint drive to demolish the alleged unauthorised construction immediately, rather than merely issuing notices, and register cases against the hotel owners.

Hotel administration on edge

The notice issued by MIDC has reportedly put the hotel administration on edge. With residents now watching closely, attention has turned to whether MIDC and the municipal administration will act to demolish the structure if the hotel owners fail to remove the construction within the stipulated deadline.

KALASAGAR OWNER RESPONDS

Hotel Kalasagar owner Ashok Bhosale rejected the allegations, saying the construction carried out on the premises was well within permissible limits and backed by documentation.

"We have carried out 2,000 square feet of construction on the Hotel Kalasagar premises. However, we still have 2 lakh square feet of FSI remaining unused. Following the complaint filed with the municipal corporation, officials came and conducted an inspection. However, this construction falls within MIDC's jurisdiction, and we have shown them all the relevant documents as well. We have demonstrated that the construction on the MIDC plot is not unauthorised," Bhosale said.

APP THAT CUTS PAPERWORK

Developed by a deputy teacher, the offline application helps manage student data, academic records, results and essential documents on mobile phones

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Teachers have to devote considerable time to several administrative tasks alongside school teaching, including collecting student information, preparing results, maintaining daily records, and preparing various types of reports and essential documents. The continuous flow of information sought by the administration and the paperwork involved in maintaining records creates a considerable workload for teachers.

To reduce this burden on teachers and save their time, Sandeep Waghmore, a deputy teacher at Jadhavwadi Kanya School of the Pimpri-Chinchwad Municipal Corporation, has taken a commendable step. He has developed a highly useful mobile app for teachers called 'Majha Varg'.

The app has been designed in a manner that makes it easy to use on a mobile phone. As a result, even teachers who face difficulties using computers, laptops or Excel will now be able to access student information and academic records easily with just one click.

KEY FEATURES OF THE APP

- Enter information only once: Student information needs to be entered in the app only once. The same data can then be used for various academic and administrative tasks throughout the year.
- More than 50 sample entries: More than 50 sample entries for each subject are already available in the app. Teachers only need to select the required entry from the dropdown menu. The app also provides a facility to add their own entries, thereby reducing the hassle of repeated typing and saving time.
- Documents available in PDF format: Bonafide certificates, leaving certificates, progress reports (results) and other required lists can be prepared directly in PDF format through the mobile phone. This will eliminate dependence on computers.
- Data backup and restore facility: A backup facility has been provided to ensure that the information entered by teachers remains secure. The same data can also be used in the following academic year, eliminating the need to go through the exercise of entering new information every year.
- Guidance videos: To ensure that teachers do not face any difficulty while using the app, informative and instructional videos have also been made available within the app.

> "I developed this app with the thought that teachers should spend more time on quality teaching for students rather than being burdened by administrative work. It has a simple design that can be easily understood by teachers of all age groups.
>
> **— Sandeep Waghmore,** App creator

'Digital assistant' for educators

The app has been made available on the Google Play Store under the name 'Majha Varg, Teachers Smart App'. Soon after its launch, more than 100 teachers installed the app within a short period, and it has received a five-star rating.



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Works without internet

The most important and distinctive feature of the app is that it does not require an internet connection to be used. Therefore, teachers facing internet network problems, as well as those working in remote and rural areas of the State, will also be able to carry out all their work accurately in offline mode.

The creator of the app, deputy teacher Sandeep Waghmore, said, "I developed this app with the thought that teachers should spend more time on quality teaching for students rather than being burdened by administrative work. It has a simple design that can be easily understood by teachers of all age groups."

The technology-friendly 'Majha Varg' initiative is being widely appreciated in education circles as it will save teachers hours spent on administrative work. The time saved can now be used for students' academic progress, leading to considerable appreciation for the app and teacher Sandeep Waghmore.

ROAD DUG UP, THEN ABANDONED

Excavated for new water pipeline, street in Tathawade allegedly left unrepaired; residents claim repeated complaints have gone unanswered

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With Ganeshotsav just days away, residents and motorists in Tathawade are bearing the brunt of the alleged shoddy functioning of the civic administration's roads and water supply officials under the 'J' Ward Office. A few days ago, the Pimpri-Chinchwad Municipal Corporation's water supply department dug up a road to lay a new pipeline. However, after the work was completed, the contractor and officials allegedly left the site without carrying out either temporary or permanent repairs. A large pothole has consequently formed on the road and has now become a major accident-prone spot. Residents are asking: the road was dug up, but who is responsible for repairing it?

Rain worsens the hazard

Over the past few days, heavy rain in the city has resulted in large potholes appearing at several places on the roads. These potholes are filling up with a considerable amount of water. Since the water level in the potholes appears to be at the same level as the road surface, motorists — particularly two-wheeler riders — are unable to gauge their depth.

Two-wheelers skid when they suddenly enter the potholes, resulting in minor and major accidents on a daily basis. Several riders have been injured, with some suffering serious injuries. Local residents fear the road is gradually turning into a death trap at night, as streetlights remain inadequate.

Festival rush raises the stakes

The arrival of the beloved 'Bappa' is only a few days away. During the festival, roads witness heavy movement of citizens and Ganesh mandal workers. In such a situation, the dangerous pothole on the main road could spoil festive celebrations. There is a strong possibility that it could cause major difficulties for mandals bringing idols to their respective locations or during immersion processions. Residents are demanding that the civic administration at least repair the road before the festival begins.



With repairs still pending, the road poses a grave accident risk to daily commuters

Officials accused of ignoring complaints

Local residents have alleged that officials from the civil engineering and water supply departments of the municipal corporation's 'J' Ward Office are completely ignoring the problem. Despite citizens repeatedly complaining about the pothole and the accidents occurring every day, officials from the concerned departments have not even inspected the site so far. The sloppy and indifferent functioning of officials has triggered considerable anger among residents.

Slipshod repair work alleged

Road excavation was carried out in the Jadhavvasti area of Tathawade to lay a water supply pipeline. After the pipeline was laid, the road was allegedly not properly filled back and asphalted — officials are said to have simply poured water on the road before leaving the site. Local residents have made it clear that if any major accident, including one resulting in loss of life, occurs because of this pothole, officials of the civil engineering and water supply departments will be held directly responsible.

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5

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PUNCHLINES WITHOUT BORDERS

Why Indian comedians are taking their shows abroad

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From Mumbai to Melbourne, Delhi to Dubai, Indian comedy is increasingly crossing borders. What was once largely a domestic stand-up circuit has now become a regular international touring business, with comedians taking their latest specials to packed venues across the US, UK, Canada, Australia, Europe and Asia.

The names on this growing international circuit include Vir Das, Zakir Khan, Anubhav Singh Bassi, Rohan Joshi, Amit Tandon, Aakash Gupta, Jaspreet Singh, Harsh Gujral, Kaneez Surka and Ravi Gupta, among others. A May 2026 report listed 18 Indian comedians touring abroad that summer, describing the phenomenon as a yearly migration of Indian comics towards overseas theatres, comedy clubs and festival venues.

Among the comedians making a strong international impact is Ravi Gupta. His show, "Kal Ki Chinta Nahi Karta," travelled across India, the US, Canada, the UK, Europe, Nepal, Vietnam, Thailand and Singapore before reaching Australia and New Zealand in 2026. His Melbourne run even added a third show following public demand.

So, what is pulling Indian comedians towards foreign stages?

The biggest factor is the Indian diaspora. For audiences living thousands of kilometres away from India, a Hindi or Indian-language comedy show is more than entertainment. It offers familiarity — jokes about parents, weddings, relatives, Indian food, office life and the everyday experiences of growing up in India.

The economics are another major attraction. International tickets are sold in currencies such as US dollars, pounds and Australian dollars, making overseas tours commercially appealing when the venues are well attended. Amit Tandon, who has performed more than 2,500 shows globally, has also spoken about the differences between Indian and diaspora audiences and the realities of building a sustainable comedy career.

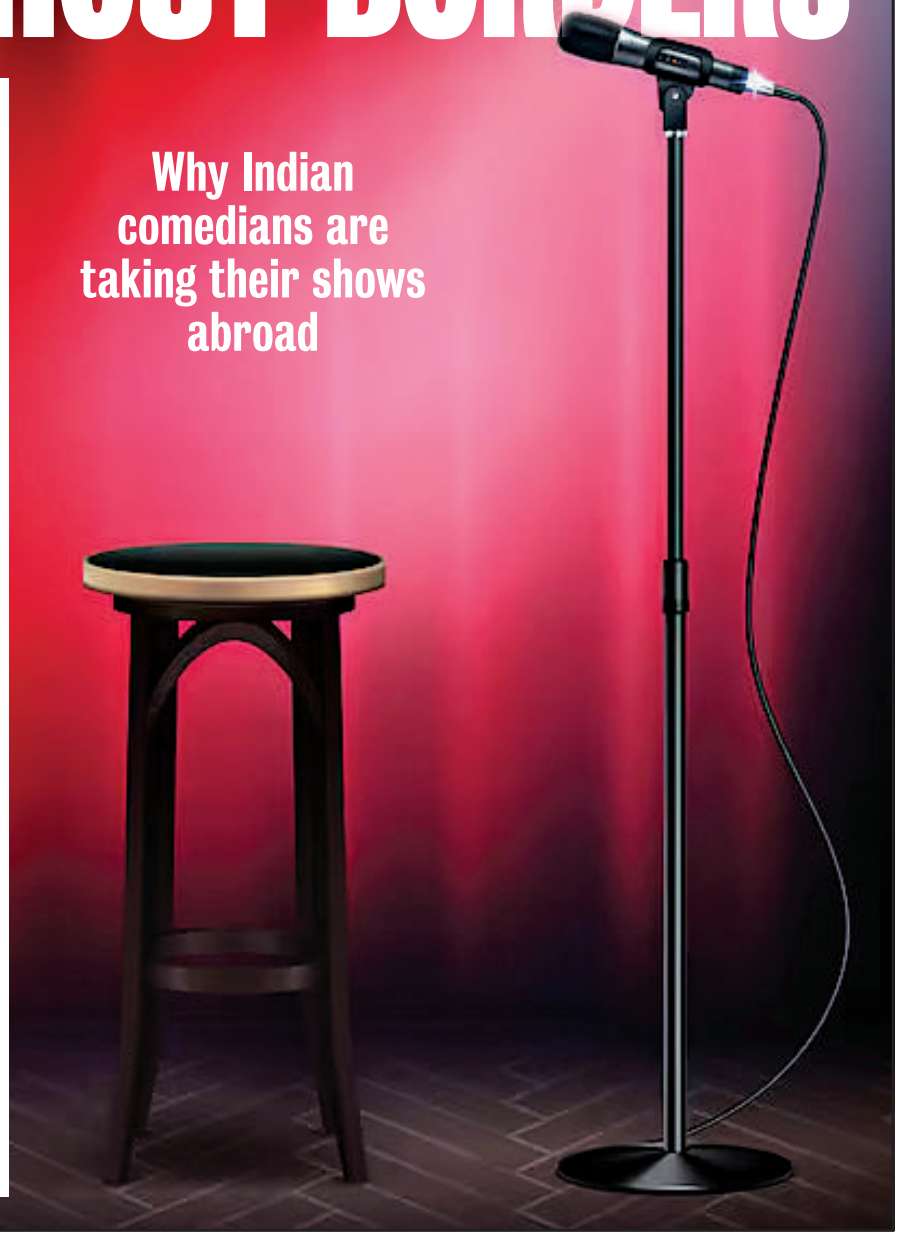
For comedians, international tours also mean a different kind of audience. A performer who has already established a fan base in India can test whether the material works beyond familiar cultural settings. For comedians like Vir Das, whose work has increasingly found a global audience, international stages have also helped position Indian stand-up as part of the wider global comedy ecosystem. Das has become one of India's most internationally recognised comedians, with his career spanning stand-up, acting and writing.

But this does not mean comedians are choosing foreign shows instead of India. Rather, the two markets are beginning to complement each other. India remains the primary source of their cultural material and fan base, while overseas tours provide additional revenue, exposure and access to a loyal diaspora audience.

There is also a larger cultural shift at play. With millions of South Asians living abroad, Indian humour no longer needs to be confined to Indian cities. The growing diaspora is creating its own demand for Indian entertainment — from music and cinema to stand-up comedy.

The result is a new comedy map where Mumbai, Delhi and Bengaluru are no longer the only destinations for a comedian's punchlines. Melbourne, London, Dubai, Toronto and New York are increasingly part of the circuit too.

For Indian comedians, the world is becoming one big comedy club — and the audience is ready to laugh.



SELECT THE BEST

Quitting sulphate shampoo? Here's what really happens to your hair



For years, a rich, foamy shampoo has been considered a sign of a proper hair wash. But as sulphate-free haircare gains popularity, many people are now wondering whether giving up sulphate-based shampoos can actually make a difference.

Sulphates are cleansing agents commonly used in shampoos to remove oil, sweat, dirt and product buildup. They also create the thick lather many people associate with clean hair. However, according to dermatologists, strong cleansing can sometimes strip away natural oils from the scalp, leaving hair feeling dry, frizzy and more prone to breakage.

The awkward transition

Switching to a sulphate-free shampoo may not immediately feel like a haircare upgrade. During the first few weeks, hair can feel heavier, greasier or less clean because there is less foam and the familiar 'squeaky-clean' sensation disappears.

Dermatologists cited in the report explain that the scalp may take some time to adjust. The transition period can last around two to four weeks, during which oil production and the way the hair feels may gradually settle.

What changes over time?

Once the scalp adjusts, the hair may retain moisture better. This can make strands feel softer and look shinier, while reduced dryness and irritation may make the scalp more comfortable. Frizz and breakage may also become less noticeable, particularly for textured, dry or chemically treated hair.

However, sulphate-free does not automatically mean 'better for everyone'. The right shampoo depends on your scalp and hair type. Academy of Dermatology recommends choosing products according to individual hair needs and focusing shampoo mainly on the scalp rather than repeatedly scrubbing the entire length of the hair.

Should you make the switch?

If you want to try good shampoo suggest transitioning gradually instead of changing your routine overnight. Alternating between your regular shampoo and a sulphate-free formula can give your scalp time to adapt.

But remember, sulphates are not the only factor behind scalp problems. Persistent dandruff, itching, flaking or irritation can have several causes and may require appropriate treatment. The American Academy of Dermatology notes that dandruff shampoos containing ingredients such as ketoconazole, selenium sulphide or salicylic acid may be recommended depending on the condition.

So, before chasing the latest "sulphate-free" trend, know your scalp. Sometimes healthier hair starts not with more products, but with choosing the right one.

Anna Hazare hospitalised in Mumbai
— Social activist Anna Hazare has been hospitalised at Bombay Hospital after his health deteriorated. He is reportedly suffering from a kidney infection. Last week, Hazare was admitted to Vedant Hospital in Shirur after experiencing urinary problems.

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FDA busts stale snacks racket

Expiry dates were being wiped out and fresh dates were being stamped in Navi Mumbai

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In a shocking discovery that should send chills down every consumer's spine, the Food and Drug Administration and Navi Mumbai Crime Branch have busted a massive racket that was quietly wiping out expiry dates on packaged snacks and stamping fresh, fake ones in their place, potentially pushing stale, unsafe food straight into your shopping bag.

What officials found there has exposed a brazen operation designed purely to cheat consumers and dodge food safety laws. The modus operandi was as simple as it was dangerous. Officials say the original manufacturing and expiry dates on packaged food were being erased and replaced with new, doctored dates. On top of that, fresh stickers were being slapped over original ingredients and nutritional information, before the entire tampered stock was repackaged and sent back into the market as if nothing had happened.

The scale of the seizure is staggering. Authorities confiscated 4,942 cartons of packaged food linked to 10 nominated exporter companies, worth a jaw dropping Rs 75,21,269. An additional stash worth roughly Rs 30,600, comprising unlabelled and expired food, was also seized on the spot.

And the list of brands caught up in this mess reads like a shopping cart from every Indian household. Lay's Classic Salted, Magic Masala, Spanish Tangy Tomato, Sizzling Hot, Lemon Chilli, Aloo and Hot & Sweet. Kurkure's entire range including Masala Munch, Red Chilli Chataka, Naughty Tomato, Solid Masti and Puffcorn Yummy Cheese. Bingo Mad Angles Achaari, Fun Flips in multiple flavours, Maggi Masala and Atta Noodles, Rasoi's ready to eat Amritsari Paneer Tikka Masala, Dum Aloo, Paneer Bhurji and Dal Makhni, Knorr Mushroom Soup, Hellmann's Mayonnaise, and even canned Thums Up and Limca.

Ten exporter firms have been named in connection with the racket, spread across Noida, Mulund, Ghatkopar, Malad, Fort, Andheri, Chembur and even Delhi. As if that wasn't damning enough, three more entities, M/s Unique Fragrances, M/s Pristine Worldwide and M/s Vipul Doshi, were found operating without valid FSSAI licences or purchase bills, and their samples have now been taken for further scrutiny.

An FIR, numbered 457/2026, has been registered at Turbhe police station invoking multiple sections of the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006, and the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023. The food licence of M/s Sadhna Enterprises has been suspended with immediate effect. FDA Commissioner Tukaram Munde did not mince words while announcing the crackdown.

"Maharashtra is extremely strict about the quality of food products and enforcement of the law. The health of consumers and the public will not be compromised under any circumstances. This kind of strict legal action will continue against anyone selling or stocking expired or tampered food products," he warned.

The operation was carried out under the guidance of Joint Commissioner Sachin Jadhav and Assistant Commissioner Ajit Maitre, with a team of FDA officers, alongside DCP Sachin Gunjal and ACP Bhausaheb Dhole of Navi Mumbai Crime Branch.

CM targets UPA govt

'Selective coverage of historical figures in textbooks'

#MUMBAI
@ThePuneMirror



Chief Minister **Devendra Fadnavis (in pic)** has targeted the previous UPA government over the NCERT historical curriculum, alleging selective coverage of historical figures in school textbooks during its tenure.

Addressing the BJP Maharashtra State Executive Meeting, Fadnavis claimed that NCERT textbooks during the UPA rule dedicated 13 pages to the Mughals while it allegedly reduced the history of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj to a single passage.

Drawing a contrast with the current administration's approach to national icons, Fadnavis stated that under Prime Minister Narendra Modi's leadership, the updated curriculum has allocated 17 pages to Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj.

Taking a further swipe at the opposition, the chief minister also accused the Congress of targeting the Ram Mandir donation controversy, alleging that the party attempted to misrepresent the issue by framing it as a case of looting.

"During the UPA era, NCERT textbooks had 13 pages for the Mughals and one passage for Shivaji. During PM Modi's time the curriculum gave 17 pages to Shivaji. Initially they opposed on issues, then they targeted the Ram temple case. They tried to set a narrative that the Ram temple was looted. Their next target is the Kumbh Mela. Come and see: Kumbh tenders were awarded at 20% lower prices..." said Fadnavis.

In a post on social media platform X, Fadnavis launched a frontal attack on Congress, accusing the opposition party of allegedly opposing the construction of the Ram Mandir and attempting to spread misleading narratives regarding the upcoming Trimbakeshwar MahaSimhastha Kumbh Mela 2027.

Widening his attack, Fadnavis targeted the Congress over the Women's Reservation Bill, accusing the party of allegedly stalling and killing the legislation during its tenure. He drew a parallel with the current administration's track record, emphasising that Prime Minister Narendra Modi has taken significant measures to empower women and youth through key initiatives such as 'Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao' and 'Lakhpati Didi' to create greater opportunities for their progress.

Outlining the state's economic and developmental roadmap, the Chief Minister reaffirmed the government's resolve to achieve a $1-trillion economy for Maharashtra by 2030, while contributing toward the broader vision of a 'Viksit Maharashtra' and a 'Viksit Bharat' by 2047. **ANI**

Bappa ready for foreign shores

The trend for idols in 'Dhotar-Pheta' and diamond work sees high demand

Pramod Patil
feedback@punemirror.com
@ThePuneMirror



Pen, known as the home of Ganesh idols, is witnessing significant demand for its exquisite and beautiful Ganesha idols again this year. Sculptors have reported that 90 per cent of the demand is for eco-friendly idols made from 'Shadu' (clay). Pen's idols are exported not just across India, but also to countries including the USA, Bangkok, and Thailand, with shipments beginning as early as February and March. There is a substantial demand for these exports again this year. With less than 20 days remaining until the Ganeshotsav festival, there is a buzz of activity in the factories.

This year, alongside traditional idols such as the Titwala Ganesha, Dagdusheth Halwai, and Lalbaugcha Raja, there is a strong preference for idols adorned in traditional dhotar (dhoti) and pheta (turban), as well as those featuring intricate diamond jewellery work. While sculptors create new designs using fresh moulds every year and traditional favourites like Lalbaugcha Raja and Siddhivinayak remain in constant demand, there is a noticeable shift towards devotees purchasing uniquely styled idols this year.

Significantly, the purchases indicate a strong inclination among devotees towards celebrating an eco-friendly Ganeshotsav. Factory owners report that over 90 per cent of the idols purchased are made from eco-friendly Shadu clay, suggesting that this year's festival will be celebrated with grandeur and enthusiasm, whilst being environmentally conscious.

Significantly, the purchases indicate a strong inclination among devotees towards celebrating an eco-friendly Ganeshotsav

> "With less than 20 days remaining, we are focusing on completing as many idols as possible. Interestingly, bookings for next year's idols have already begun
> **— Sculptor Sonali Pawar,** sculptor

Sculptor Sonali Pawar notes that thousands of Ganesh idols wearing pheta and dhotar with diamond work have already been sent abroad, and demand continues. "With less than 20 days remaining, we are focusing on completing as many idols as possible. Interestingly, bookings for next year's idols have already begun," she says.

She further highlights the social impact, noting that 20 to 25 women work in their factory throughout the year, providing them with stable, year-round employment. "This is a great opportunity for them, as they have found steady work and financial independence. In fact, in these idol factories, women are now moving ahead of men in terms of participation."

The work on idols for the following year begins immediately after Ganesh Chaturthi and continues throughout the year. There is also good demand for goddess idols for the upcoming Navratri festival. Sonali Pawar expresses satisfaction that this year-round business is providing meaningful and consistent employment opportunities for women.



PROTECT SEAFARERS: MODI

Ensure freedom of navigation, commerce: PM to Iran President

#WASHINGTON
@ThePuneMirror

Prime Minister Narendra Modi held bilateral talks with Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian on Monday on the sidelines of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) Summit in Bishkek and urged the protection of commercial shipping and insisting that seafarers and civilians must not be harmed amid the ongoing West Asia conflict.

Following the meeting, the Ministry of External Affairs spokesperson stated that the two leaders discussed bilateral ties, trade, the prevailing situation in West Asia and the safety of seafarers

"The two leaders discussed various aspects of bilateral ties. They reviewed recent developments in the West Asia region. Prime Minister reiterated India's consistent position that all issues must be resolved through dialogue and diplomacy. Prime Minister also underlined the need for continued efforts to ensure peace and stability in the region and for safeguarding freedom of navigation and commerce," MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said in a statement.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi holds a bilateral meeting with Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian on the sidelines of the SCO Summit, in Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan, on Monday ANI

Reiterating India's readiness to closely cooperate with Iran in multilateral organisations, including BRICS and SCO, Prime Minister Modi conveyed to Pezeshkian that he looked forward to welcoming the Iranian President to India for the BRICS Summit scheduled in New Delhi on September 12-13.

Prime Minister Modi also expressed New Delhi's resolve to "expand and diversify" bilateral trade channels with Iran, emphasising the country's dedication to deepening historic ties across multiple domains.

Sharing details of the engagement on social media, PM Modi posted, "Met President Masoud Pezeshkian in Bishkek. Reiterated our commitment to strengthening India's long-standing friendship with Iran across diverse sectors."

"We want to expand and diversify our trade basket in the times to come. We had a discussion on the prevailing situation in the region. India will continue to support all efforts aimed at ensuring lasting peace," he added.

Ministry of External Affairs spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal noted that the two leaders conducted a "fruitful meeting" focused on bilateral cooperation and a review of geopolitical dynamics across West Asia.

"Prime Minister reiterated India's consistent position that all issues must be resolved through dialogue and diplomacy," Jaiswal shared online, adding that the Prime Minister stressed the necessity of sustained initiatives to promote regional stability, security, and the protection of maritime commerce.

The high-level discussions took place against the backdrop of ongoing conflicts in West Asia impacting regional stability, commercial navigation and maritime logistics.

Iranian Foreign Minister Seyed Abbas Araghchi, along other senior delegates from Tehran, were among those who attended the bilateral meeting between the Indian Prime Minister and Iranian President.

PM Modi is on an official visit to Kyrgyzstan to attend the 26th SCO Summit and the opening ceremony of the 6th World Nomad Games.

AGENCIES

Trump goes ballistic

Reiterates claims of Iran's military destruction

#WASHINGTON
@ThePuneMirror

US President **Donald Trump (in pic)** on Monday yet again reiterated the claims of military annihilation of Iran, while also asserting that oil continues to flow out of the Strait of Hormuz with the "Navy's assistance", due to which prices have not shot up.

He made the remarks while speaking to the media from the Oval Office.

When asked about Iran, the US President said, "They're a failed nation. Yeah, they're a failed nation. They've got 350 per cent inflation. They have no currency. They're not paying their soldiers. Their leaders are largely dead. Their Navy is gone. Their Air Force is gone. Their surveillance equipment is almost entirely gone. That doesn't mean we won't smack them. See what happens."

On the situation in the Strait of Hormuz and the role being played by US Navy, Trump told the reporters, "We have the Strait of Hormuz in extremely good shape. You know, we're taking over many, many ships that got through last night, as you know, with the Navy's assistance. And we've been averaging 30 ships a night. That's a lot. And a lot of oil is coming out. That's why you haven't seen the price of oil go like they thought it might have to go."

He reiterated the stance of Washington to never allow Tehran to acquire nukes, claiming that if Iran had nuclear weapons, Israel and West



Asia would have been "wiped out".

Trump said, "Iran will never have a nuclear weapon. See, that's what it's all about. It's not about any of the other things. It's about us as a country and as for the world, Iran cannot have a nuclear weapon. If Iran had a nuclear weapon, Israel would have been wiped out. You would have no Israel right now and probably no Middle East. And they'd be hitting our cities at some point because they're sick people. And Iran will never have a nuclear weapon."

Following the US strike, Iran claimed to have launched ballistic missiles at two US air bases in Jordan, Press TV reported.

On the other hand, the Iranian Army claimed that it carried out drone strikes targeting helicopter and troop positions at the Al Minhad airbase in the UAE. **AGENCIES**

Tehran open to talks

US should return to its commitments: Pezeshkian

#BISHKEK
@ThePuneMirror

Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian on Tuesday said that Iran would "immediately reciprocate" if the United States returned to its commitments under the 14-point Memorandum of Understanding (MoU), according to the official website of the President of Iran.

Addressing the 26th Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) Summit in Bishkek, Pezeshkian said that Iran had a "brilliant record" of fulfilling its international obligations and treaties, while warning that unilateral policies, military force, illegal sanctions and geopolitical competition were threatening regional and global stability.

"The attacks carried out by the United States and the Zionist regime (Israel) against Iran on June 13, 2025 and February 28, 2026 were a clear violation of the fundamental principles of the United Nations Charter and international law, against the principle of prohibition of the use of force, and against the right to life," he said.

Pezeshkian said recent developments in West Asia, including in Iran, Lebanon, Gaza and the West Bank, had shown that disregard for international law and approaches based on force and pressure threatened the security of countries as well as regional and global stability. He said the strikes on Iran resulted in large-scale



FILE PHOTO

casualties, including strikes on a school in Minab and a stadium in Lamerd, Fars Province.

"These were just three examples of the great crimes of the first day of a 40-day war. In the face of this volume of brutality, the Islamic Republic of Iran, relying on the great power of its brave and zealous armed forces and enjoying the nationwide support of its noble nation, inflicted heavy and strategic defeats on the United States and the occupying regime and achieved brilliant victories," he said.

Pezeshkian said the strikes were an assault on an SCO member state and an "ancient civilisation", while expressing appreciation to the organisation and countries that condemned the aggression and expressed sympathy with Iran.

He said that following 40 days of "resistance" by the Iranian people and, according to Pezeshkian's claim that the US "failed" to achieve its "predetermined goals", a ceasefire and an end to the conflict were forced.

Pezeshkian said nearly three months of negotiations mediated by Pakistan and Qatar subsequently led to the 14-point MoU. **AGENCIES**

HEALTH TIP: Walnuts are widely considered the best dry fruit for heart health because they are packed with plant-based omega-3 fatty acids that reduce inflammation and protect your blood vessels.



Eating 4 to 7 walnuts daily is advised, but overconsumption can lead to digestive distress

Pune Times Mirror | 14
Wednesday, September 2, 2026
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ASK THE SEXPERT



DR ROHAN JAHAGIRDAR
Psychiatrist & Sexpert

1 I'm a 20-year-old male. I find most condoms are yellow in color. Is it made in this specific color so one is constantly aware about being cautious while having sex?
Dear Sir, No that is Not the reason. I think you are over thinking and reading too much into the colours. Because by that logic if you buy a red colour condom you should not be having sex! Hope you find the answer COLOURFUL! (pun intended)

2 I'm a 42-year-old woman.I've read that Japanese green tea is very good for health as it enhances one's sexual performance. Is that true?
Ma'am, Yes it is associated with boosting immunity, also reducing fatigue and in certain cases it is also considered as a natural aphrodisiac. However, it can aid in maintaining an overall healthy lifestyle but not as a treatment for medical or sexual conditions.

3 I'm a 27-year-old girl. I went for a foot massage on my Holiday and felt I was getting turned on. Can feet be a pleasurable point?
Ma'am, the feet have many nerve endings and the idea of being touched could have led to you having sensual thoughts. It can normally happen and for this very reason couples indulge in touching different body parts as a part of foreplay.

4 I'm a 48-year-old woman. Can menopause make my sexual intercourse painful?
Dear Ma'am, the menopause can lead to vaginal dryness which is one of the commonest reasons for the painful intercourse. You can try using a vaginal moisturizer or a lubricant but do see a doctor to address the overall symptoms of your menopause.

SEND YOUR QUERIES RELATED TO SEXUAL PROBLEMS TO
sexpert@punemirror.com



IT'S NOT ONE-SIZE, FITS-ALL...

Lifestyle risks weigh heavier on women's hearts: Study

Lifestyle and health factors that are linked with heart disease appear to have a greater impact on cardiovascular risk in women than men, a study at the American College of Cardiology's Annual Scientific Session has found.

While diet, exercise, smoking, and blood pressure have long been associated with heart disease risk, the new study is the first to indicate that these correlations are higher in women than in males.

According to the researchers, the findings indicate that sex-specific screening or risk assessment methodologies could provide a more realistic picture of cardiovascular risk and better drive people to adopt heart-healthy habits.

"For the same level of health, our study shows that the increase in risk (related to each factor) is higher in women than in men--it's not one-size-fits-all," said Maneesh Sud, MD, PhD, assistant professor in the department of medicine, interventional cardiologist and clinician scientist at Sunnybrook Health Sciences Centre in Toronto and the study's lead author. "This is novel and something that hasn't been seen in other studies."

The Eight Factors

The study focused on eight factors associated with heart disease: diet, sleep, physical activity, smoking, body mass index, blood glucose, lipids and blood pressure.

Overall, the results showed that women were more likely to have fewer negative risk factors and more positive ones compared with men. However, women with more negative risk factors faced a more pronounced increase in their chance of a heart attack, stroke or other cardiovascular event compared to men with a similar risk factor profile.

"We found that women tend to have better health than men, but the impact on outcomes is different," Sud said. "The combination of these factors has a bigger impact in women than it does in men."



The researchers analysed data from over 175,000 Canadian adults who enrolled in the Ontario Health Study between 2009-2017. None of the participants had heart disease at baseline and about 60% were women. Each participant was classified as having ideal or poor health in terms of each of the eight risk factors, and these scores were combined to calculate an overall risk factor profile as poor (fewer than five positive factors or more than three negative factors), intermediate (five to seven positive factors) or ideal (ideal across all eight factors).

Heart Disease Outcomes

During a median follow-up period of just over 11 years, researchers tracked the incidence of seven heart disease outcomes--heart attack, stroke, unstable angina (chest pain that results from restricted blood flow to the heart), peripheral arterial disease (narrowed blood vessels in the arms or legs), heart failure, coronary revascularization (procedures to open blocked arteries) and cardiovascular death--among participants in each of the three groupings.

In the study population, significantly more women were categorized as having ideal health, with 9.1% of women and 4.8% of men scoring a perfect 8 out of 8. Women were also less likely to be categorized as having poor health, with 21.9% of women and 30.5% of men falling into this category. In terms of individual risk factors, women were more likely than men to have ideal diet, blood glucose, cholesterol and blood pressure, while women were slightly less likely than men to have ideal physical activity levels.

After adjusting for age, the results showed that participants of both sexes saw an elevated risk of heart disease if they had poor or intermediate health compared to those with ideal health, but these differences were more extreme in women than men.

Women with poor health had nearly five times the risk of heart disease as women with ideal health, while men with poor health had 2.5 times the risk of heart disease as men with ideal health. Women with intermediate health had 2.3 times the risk as those with ideal health, while men with intermediate health had 1.6 times the risk as those with ideal health.

Common Signs to Watch For

Eat A Heart-Healthy Diet

- Load up on fiber: Eat more whole grains, beans, fruits, and vegetables.
- Choose healthy fats: Use olive oil and eat fish like salmon, which provides omega-3 fats.
- Cut down on salt and sugar: Limit processed foods, salty snacks, and sugary drinks to control blood pressure.
- Follow proven plans: Try the Mediterranean or DASH eating patterns, which focus on fresh produce and lean proteins.

Move Regularly

- Exercise weekly: Aim for at least 150 minutes of moderate activity, like brisk walking or cycling, every week
- Add strength training: Do muscle-strengthening exercises at least two days a week
- Move more daily: Take the stairs, do household chores, or take short five-minute walking breaks if you sit for long periods

Build Healthy Habits

- Quit smoking: Avoid cigarettes and secondhand smoke entirely to protect your blood vessels
- Manage stress: Use deep breathing, meditation, or yoga to lower tension
- Sleep well: Get 7 to 9 hours of quality sleep every night
- Check your numbers: Visit your doctor regularly to monitor your blood pressure, cholesterol, and blood sugar levels

(Courtesy: American Heart Association)

The Quest Continues

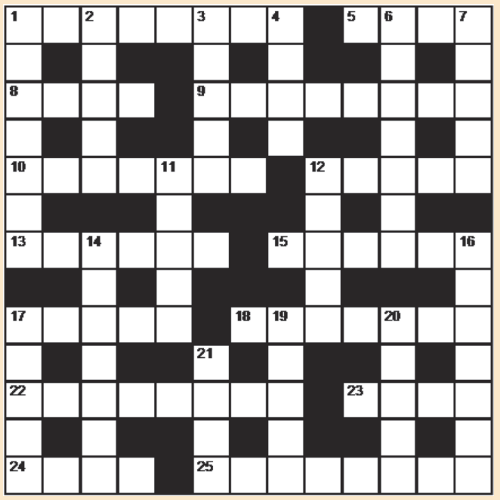
Further study is needed to understand how each factor might be affecting outcomes differently in men and women based on either biological or sociocultural factors, the researchers said.

The researchers plan to conduct additional analyses to determine whether there are any differences in risk factor impacts among people of different racial and ethnic groups or among women before and after menopause.

Chai-Time

Kidzone, Pune Mirror, email us at mirrorfeatures@gmail.com

QUICK 6681

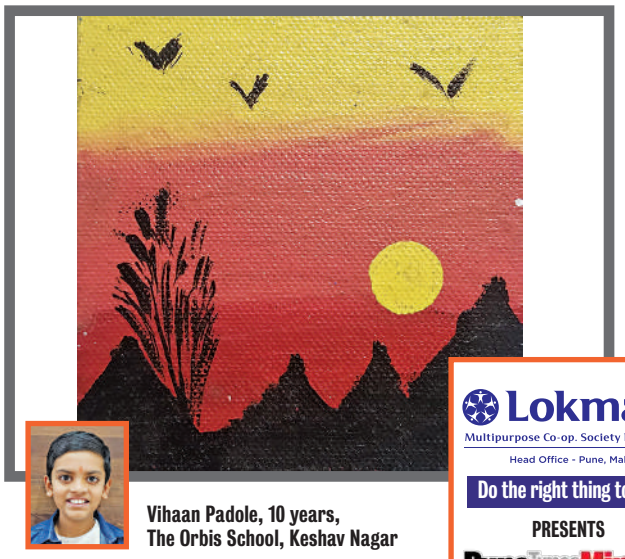


ACROSS
1 Soap or detergent? (8)
5 Cantonment and Koregaon Park area of Pune (4)
8 Take it easy (4)
9 Coming before in position or time (8)
10 Oversight (7)
12 Sums owing (5)
13 Germinate (6)
15 Manufacturers (6)
17 Underworld river (5)
18 Vatican chapel (7)
22 Encouragement to and support of an offence (8)
23 Bath tablet (4)
24 Ballet skirt (4)
25 Member of staff (8)

DOWN
1 Newspaper features (7)
2 New York island? (5)
3 Loose or limp (5)
4 Tracks of wheels in soft earth (4)
6 Friendly or agreeable (7)
7 Tiny openings in the skin (5)
11 The blue of the sky (5)
12 Loved ones, in a manner of speaking? (5)
14 Military retirement (7)
16 Church spire (7)
17 Minimal (5)
19 __ ___ form: like that batsman who goes on scoring hundreds after hundreds? (2,3)
20 Elephant tusk (5)
21 Apportion (4)

FOR ANSWER SCAN ↓

Please send copies of your children's artworks along with a photo of the artist in A4 size.
Do mention their age and the name of the school they attend. You can also mail us unpublished poems by children.



Vihaan Padole, 10 years,
The Orbis School, Keshav Nagar



Aradhya Dattatray Khaire, 10 years,
Priyadarshani School, Moshi

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Pratyush Sushil Kumbhar, 6 years,
Priyadarshani School, Moshi





Atul Shinde, 11 years,
MIT Vishwashanti Gurukul School

WHAT YOUR STARS SAY TODAY

Aries
March 21 - April 20

You'll start seeing positive results from the initiatives you launched three weeks ago. If you spread your energy too thin, it may feel like you're not getting anywhere. What you need is a break from your daily routine.

Taurus
April 21 - May 20

Favorable connections are starting to open up. Look past appearances—you might surprise yourself. You may be feeling a dip in energy, so don't ignore it. Pay closer attention to your sleep, and consider adding some physical activity to your routine.

Gemini
May 21 - June 21

Don't get dragged into pointless, absurd arguments. Skip the useless debates—today, you're especially likely to be pulled in. Lately, your eating habits have thrown your system out of balance, and it's time to reset now.

Cancer
June 22 - July 23

Nothing will dim your great mood today. The sky is smiling at you—and you'll smile right back. Your doubts can't touch who you are, and your outside relationships are supportive too, making everything better—almost effortlessly.

Leo
July 24 – August 23

If you steer clear of a few indulgences and know how to resist temptations that can feel a little unsettling, you'll have plenty to be happy about today—an emotional, opportunity-filled day in every direction. The sky is on your side, bringing you a glow and charisma like no other.

Virgo
August 24 - September 23

The spotlight is on your creativity—it can help you in a big way. Don't keep your ideas in the dark; they hold real power. You'll be more receptive to microbes and bacteria. Conserve your energy and don't overexpose yourself!

Libra
September 24 - October 22

The sky is shining, and it refreshes your perspective. Your imagination is running wild, and the future is starting to take shape in the best possible light. You feel ready to see clearly what could free you from the fears and timidity that have been holding back your growth.

Scorpio
October 23 - November 22

Step away from negative people—you need optimism. Put yourself first more than ever. You'll tune in to your natural needs and learn how to turn them into an advantage. You'll also find a smarter balance between rest and action.

Sagittarius
November 23 - December 22

It's a particularly intense day, and you'll need to manage it as best you can for your own benefit. You're taking on too much at once, and the people around you may make it harder to see the exact path you need to follow to reach your goals.

Capricorn
December 23 - January 20

You don't hesitate to put your imagination to work and break free from your routine. An escape is calling your name. Your vitality draws you into conversations and meaningful exchanges that lift your spirit and recharge you from the inside out.

Aquarius
January 21 - February 19

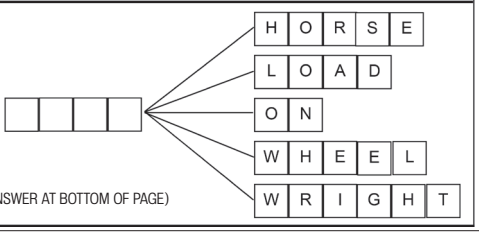
Your stubbornness can steer you into dead ends. Pause before you push your plan forward. Small annoyances can quickly harden into fixed ideas—so look for the nuance.

Pisces
February 20 - March 20

Holding yourself together isn't the same as holding back from life. You can afford to express yourself more—naturally. You're going to learn a lot about someone in your circle. Keep it to yourself.

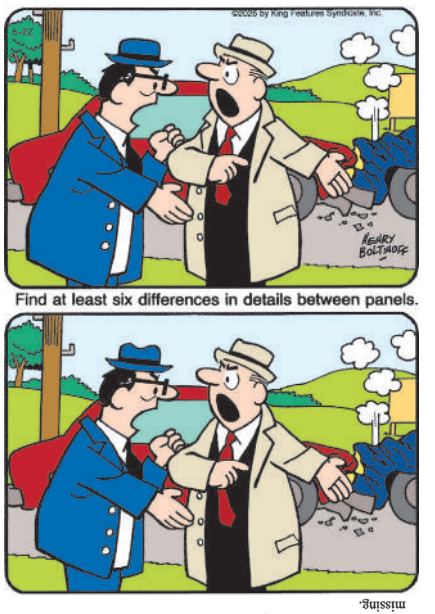
DOUBLE - BARRELLED

What word can be placed in front of the five words shown to form in each case another word ?



(ANSWER AT BOTTOM OF PAGE)

HOCUSFOCUS



Find at least six differences in details between panels.

Differences: 1. Hat is different. 2. Pocket is lower. 3. Tie is longer. 4. Jacket is shorter. 5. Lapel is missing. 6. Tree trunk is missing.

ANSWER FOR DOUBLE-BARRELLED : Cart

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BADSHAH & ISHA RIKHI CALL IT QUITS



Bollywood and the Punjabi entertainment industry woke up to a surprise announcement as rapper-singer Badshah and actor Isha Rikhi confirmed that they have decided to part ways. The couple shared a joint statement on Instagram Stories on Monday night, putting an end to weeks of speculation surrounding their relationship.

In their statement, Badshah and Isha made it clear that the decision was mutual and that they wanted to move ahead on separate paths with respect for each other.

"I and Isha Rikhi have mutually decided to part ways and move forward on our separate paths. This decision has been made with mutual respect," Badshah wrote. The couple also requested fans and the media to respect their privacy and avoid further speculation about their relationship.

The announcement comes just five months after their wedding. The couple reportedly got married in an intimate ceremony in March 2026, with news of the wedding emerging after photographs were shared by Isha's mother, Poonam Rikhi. Badshah and Isha had largely kept their relationship away from the spotlight.

However, rumours about trouble in their relationship had been circulating on social media for several weeks. In July, Isha shared a montage of photographs and videos featuring herself and Badshah, accompanied by the caption, "Every storm is a lesson. Every prayer is hope." The emotional post quickly caught the attention of social media users and sparked questions about whether all was well between the couple.

Neither Badshah nor Isha publicly addressed the speculation at the time. Their latest statement now confirms that the relationship has ended, while also making it clear that they do not want to discuss the reasons behind their decision.

For Badshah, this is his second marriage to end in divorce. He was previously married to Jasmine Masih, with whom he shares a daughter. The couple finalised their divorce in 2020 and have continued to co-parent their child.

Isha Rikhi, meanwhile, is known for her work in Punjabi cinema and made her Hindi film debut with Nawabzaade in 2018. She has appeared in films including Ardaas and Mindo Taseeldarni.

For now, both Badshah and Isha appear to be choosing a quiet exit rather than a public post-mortem of their relationship. Their message is simple: the decision was mutual, the next chapter will be separate, and they would like everyone to respect their space.



Kareena dodges Kriti Sanon outfit question

Kareena Kapoor Khan found herself in an unexpected spot at the trailer launch of her upcoming film Daayra when a question about actresses, outfits and trolling came her way. With the ongoing controversy surrounding Kriti Sanon's Raksha Bandhan advertisement making headlines, Kareena was asked whether she has any personal boundaries regarding the clothes she wears on screen.

However, Bebo appeared hesitant to answer the question. That is when director Meghna Gulzar stepped in and offered her take, saying that an actor's clothes in a film are primarily decided according to the character and the director's vision.



Meghna explained that whether the actor is a man or a woman, the wardrobe should suit the character being portrayed. She also pointed out that it is unfair to direct such a question towards just one actor.

The question came amid the social media controversy surrounding Kriti Sanon's appearance in a jewellery brand's Raksha Bandhan advertisement. Kriti was seen wearing an Indo-Western outfit featuring a bralette-style blouse, cape and draped skirt while celebrating the festival with her brother and tying a rakhi to their pet dog. The campaign received criticism from some quarters over its styling and portrayal of the festival.

Kriti later addressed the backlash herself, questioning why women continue to be told what they should and should not wear. She argued that cultural values should not be judged simply by a woman's neckline or clothing choices.

The controversy grew further after Kangana Ranaut criticised the advertisement, while the jewellery brand eventually withdrew the campaign following the backlash.

Against this backdrop, Kareena's decision not to get drawn into the outfit debate appeared particularly noticeable. Rather than turning the Daayra promotional event into another discussion around fashion policing, the focus soon returned to the film.

Daayra marks Kareena's first collaboration with filmmaker Meghna Gulzar. The film features Kareena opposite Malayalam star Prithviraj Sukumaran, with both actors playing police officers who find themselves on opposite sides of a complicated moral line. Meghna has described Kareena's character, DCP Ajooni Kohli, as fiercely righteous, while Prithviraj's DCP Raman Kumar is portrayed as intense and uncompromising.

For now, Kareena seems happy to let her work do the talking. And Meghna's message was equally clear — when it comes to an actor's screen wardrobe, the character should have the final say, not social-media debates.